In the fall of 1950, Acheson had told members of Congress that the Chinese going into Tibet made Delhi realize that the "force that is loose in China is a pretty difficult one to handle."[196] The American hope that India would recognize Mao's aggressive intentions in Asia only escalated when the Chinese subsequently intervened in the Korean War.

Even though its efforts in summer and early fall 1950 had met with little success, the Indian role as intermediary between China and the US had continued. Washington usually considered India's nonalignment and its relations with China a liability, but, along with Panikkar's access to Chinese officials, these were seen as assets when the US needed a channel to China. Britain also had a presence in Beijing. But American officials thought Nehru and India had more credibility in Asia and the nonaligned world, and India had been willing to take on this role. From the start of the war, Indian officials had briefed American officials on the messages they received from Panikkar.[197] In turn, India had passed on American messages to China, including warnings intended to deter Beijing.[198] But some US policymakers doubted India's role as an honest broker. India was not an ally, and it followed an independent China policy that they believed was primarily designed to avoid provoking Beijing. This added to the strain in the US-India relationship.

American doubts about the messenger were partly responsible for skepticism about Chinese signals via Delhi in September and October that it would intervene directly in the war if UN forces crossed the 38th parallel dividing North and South Korea.[199] Some policymakers saw the accompanying Indian warning as driven by Nehru wanting peace at any cost. Skepticism of Panikkar affected others' views.[200] American officials thought he was not objective about the Chinese—a concern that Indian officials like Bajpai and Pandit shared.[201] Yet others, including Truman, believed that China was trying to influence a vote pending at the UN, and that the messages were either just Chinese propaganda or "a bald attempt to blackmail the UN." Moreover, MacArthur had assured the president that China was unlikely to intervene.[202]

Allies, as well as some in American military and political circles, worried about potential Chinese escalation if the 38th parallel was crossed. But Truman was even more concerned about global and domestic credibility, and military demands.[203] Thus, despite India's and others'